

Boxes For Your Bytes

Opening up a PC is not child's play for everyone. External hard drives give you the convenience and ease of moving data—just plug 'n' play!

Jayesh Limaye

Hard drives were initially manufactured exclusively for research and development institutes and mainframes. Now they are, of course, mass-produced for our computers, and today, hard drives come under the consumer electronics segment. According to CNET, hard drive shipments for consumer electronics worldwide will grow by about 35 per cent this year—a huge increase from last year. The overall hard drive market is projected to increase by 18 per cent by the end of this year.

A few months ago, we reviewed DVD-Writers, which are the most popular data backup devices. But DVDs are limited in terms of capacity, so backing up a large hard disk using these is extremely difficult. Now, you could, of course, use another hard disk to back up your data, but then, what if you don't have free bays in your cabinet? What if you need to synchronise data between home and office?

Enter portable hard drives. These devices today have capacities on par with those of their internal counterparts. External hard drives allow you to exchange games, movies, music and other stuff with friends. Besides, not everyone is comfortable with opening up the PC cabinet and connecting an internal hard drive to swap data. An external drive spells convenience.

As hard drives celebrate their 50th birthday, we bring you a shootout of external hard drives available in the Indian market. We received a total of 18 external drives from Freecom, Iomega, LaCie, Qrisma, Seagate, Transcend and Western Digital. We divided these into three categories: portable hard drives, desktop replacement / backup drives, and microdrive-based hard drives.

The first segment—*Portable hard drives*—comprises the drives with a capacity of 120 GB or less. Drives with more features, and larger than 120 GB, comprised the second segment—*Desktop replacement / backup drives*. And three very compact drives—something like larger versions